

Review of possessive prefixes

Here are two of the nouns we talked about last time:

basic form

skak 'child'

hinic 'language'

possessed form

bizkak 'his/her children'

bikinic 'his/her language'

Translate and write the remaining possessed forms of each word. If you think both long and short forms of 'my' and 'your (sg.)' should be possible, write both:

'my children' _____

'your children' _____

'their children' _____

'our children' _____

'your (pl.) children' _____

'my language' _____

'your language' _____

'their language' _____

'our language' _____

'your (pl.) language' _____

Postpositions

Witsuwit'en has *postpositions*. Here are some examples of postpositions. Like the use of hyphen with the possessed form of a noun, the hyphen indicates that a postposition must be preceded by something in order to be a word:

-be 'for'

-ilh 'with'

-'ët 'without'

-zuh 'beside'

What postpositions must be preceded by is a pronoun or noun. Examples with pronominal prefixes follow:

sbe 'for me'

bilh 'with her'

nyi'ët 'without you'

niwhzuh 'beside us, you pl.'

(Hence the name *postposition*: these are like prepositions except that they follow the noun or pronoun that they go with.)

Postpositional object form (first pass)

When the object of the postposition is a pronoun, a prefix is added to the postposition in Witsuwit'en. These prefixes are identical to the possessive prefixes, including the same long and short forms of 'me' and 'you (sg.)', with two exceptions, noted shortly below. First compare the following:

sbe ~ sibe 'for me'

mbe ~ nyibe 'for you'

bibe 'for him/her'

hibibe 'for them'

niwhbe 'for us, you (pl.)'

When a postposition begins with a vowel, only the long form of 'you (sg.)' is possible:

nyilh

'with you'

And the vowel **i** that normally occurs with the other postpositional prefixes drops out:

silh	'with me'
bilh	'with him/her'
niwhilh	'with you (pl.), us'
hibilh	'with them'

When a postposition begins with **z**, only the long form of 'me' is used (and the long form of 'you' is preferred):

sizuh	'by, beside me'
nyizuh ~ nzuh	'by you'
bizuh	'by him/her'
hibizuh	'by them'
niwhzuh	'by us, you (pl.)'

Usage of postpositions

Some Witsuwit'en verbs require a postpositional object. For example, 'wait for' requires the postposition **-be**. Here are some forms of 'wait for'. Notice that each form is a two-word phrase, and the prefixed postposition is the first word of the phrase:

bibe siclh'iy	'I'm waiting for him/her'
mbe ~nyibe siclh'iy	'I'm waiting for you'
hibibe siclh'iy	'I'm waiting for them'
niwhbe siclh'iy	'I'm waiting for you (pl.)'
sbe silh'iy	'he/she is waiting for me'
mbe ~nyibe silh'iy	'he/she is waiting for you'
hibibe silh'iy	'he/she is waiting for them'
niwhbe silh'iy	'he/she is waiting for us, you (pl.)'

Postpositional object form: special rules

The two differences between possessive prefixes to nouns and postpositional object prefixes mentioned above both involve the form of 'him/her'. (1) When the verb of the sentence

has a third person singular subject ('he/she/it'), the postpositional prefix meaning 'him/her' is **yi-**, not **bi-**. Compare the following:

yi be silh'iy	'he/she is waiting for him/her'
bibe sielh'iy	'I'm waiting for him/her'
bibe selh'iy	'you're waiting for him/her'
bibe ts'ilh'iy	'we're waiting for him/her'
bibe sdil'iy	'we (du.) are waiting for him/her'
bibe siwhlh'iy	'you (pl.) are waiting for him/her'

(2) When the verb of the sentence has a third person plural subject ('they'), a prefix **hiy-** is added to the postposition, and the verb may lack its normal **h-** (or vowel length) marker of third person plural subject (more on this in later lessons). Compare the following:

sbe ~ sibe hilh'iy	'they're waiting for me'
mbe ~ nyibe hilh'iy	'they're waiting for you'
hibibe hilh'iy	'they're waiting for them'
niwhbe hilh'iy	'they're waiting for us, you (pl.)'
hiy be hilh'iy ~ hiy be silh'iy	'they're waiting for him/her'

Postpositional object writing practice

Consider some forms of the verb 'talk':

yecldic	'I'm talking'
yelldic	'you're talking; he/she is talking'
yedildic	'we (du.) are talking'
yets'illdic	'we're talking'
yewhlldic	'you (pl.) are talking'
yeelldic	'they're talking'

Witsuwit'en 'talk to' requires a postpositional object using the postposition **-ilh**:

bilh yecldic	'I'm talking to him/her'
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yilh yelhdic

'he/she is talking to him/her'

bilh yelhdic

'you're talking to him/her'

silh yelhdic

'he/she is talking to me'

silh yeelhdic

'they're talking to me'

Translate the following English forms of 'talk to' into Witsuwit'en and write each two word phrase. Fill in the verb with one of the forms at the beginning of this section.

Example:

'you're talking to me'

Answer:

silh yelhdic

'you're talking to me'

_____ yewhlhdic	'you (pl.) are talking to me'
_____ yets'ilhdic	'we're talking to you'
_____ yelhdic	'he/she is talking to you'
_____ yedildic	'we (du.) are talking to you'
_____ yeclhdic	'I'm talking to you'
_____ yeelhdic	'they're talking to you'
_____ yeclhdic	'I'm talking to them'
_____ yedildic	'we (du.) are talking to them'
_____ yets'ilhdic	'we're talking to them'
_____ yeelhdic	'they're talking to them'
_____ yelhdic	'you're talking to them'
_____ yewhlhdic	'you (pl.) are talking to them'
_____ yelhdic	'he/she is talking to him/her'
_____ yelhdic	'you're talking to him/her'
_____ yewhlhdic	'you (pl.) are talking to him/her'
_____ yets'ilhdic	'we're talking to him/her'
_____ yedildic	'we (du.) are talking to him/her'
_____ yeelhdic	'they're talking to him/her'

More verbs with postpositional object

There are other verbs in Witsuwit'en which require a postpositional object, but unlike 'talk to', the postposition is part of the verb word, typically the leftmost element in the verb. Study the following forms of 'know':

budiclhye	'I know him/her/it'
nyudiclhye	'I know you'
budilhye	'you know him'
hibudilhye	'you know them'
yudilhye	'he/she knows him'
hibudilhye	'he/she knows them'
bits'udilhye	'we know him'
budidilye	'we (du.) know him'
budiwhllhye	'you (pl.) know him'
hiyudilhye	'they know him'

With these cases, there is typically only one form of 'they...him', as shown above. The **u** of 'know' changes to **o** after **s-** 'me' and **niwh-** 'us, you (pl.)':

sodilhye	'he knows me'
niwhodilhye	'he knows us, you (pl.)'

(More on this **u~o** change in a later lesson.)

Postpositional object writing practice 2

Translate and write the correct forms of the verb 'want', which has a postpositional object **-ka-** that is part of the verb word. The verb has been supplied for you minus the correct object of postposition. Fill in the correct object of postposition for each form. If you think there is more than one correct form, fill in both.

Example:

_____ka'niszin

'I want him/her/it'

Answer:

bika'niszin

'I want him/her/it'

_____ka'nīnzin	'you want him/her/it'
_____ka'nīnzin	'you want them'
_____ka'nīnzin	'you want us'
_____ka'nīnzin	'she wants him/her/it'
_____ka'nīnzin	'she wants you'
_____ka'nīnzin	'she wants me'
_____ka'nīnzin	'she wants them'
_____ka'nīnzin	'she wants us'
_____ka'nididzin	'we (du.) want you'
_____ka'nididzin	'we (du.) want you (pl.)'
_____ka'nididzin	'we (du.) want him'
_____ka'nididzin	'we (du.) want them'
_____ka'niwhzin	'you (pl.) want us'
_____ka'niwhzin	'you (pl.) want us'
_____ka'iznīnzin	'we want him/her/it'
_____ka'iznīnzin	'we want you'
_____ka'iznīnzin	'we want them'
_____ka'nīnzin	'he/she wants him/her/it'
_____ka'nīnzin	'he/she wants you (pl.)'
_____ka'nīnzin	'he/she wants me'
_____ka'aanīnzin	'they want you'
_____ka'aanīnzin	'they want you (pl.)'
_____ka'aanīnzin	'they want us'
_____ka'aanīnzin	'they want me'
_____ka'nīnzin	'they want him/her/it'